

International Marketing

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Introduction to International Marketing

What is international marketing?

International marketing is the process of planning, promoting, and pricing products or services across national borders. It requires companies to understand how foreign markets differ in areas such as culture, consumer behavior, and distribution systems (Palmer, J. 2025).

Why is it important?

- It does give companies access to new customers and sources of revenues
- It can also improve competitiveness and reduce dependence on one country.

Palmer, J. (2025, June 3). *What is international marketing and why is it important for global business success* / gisma. Gisma.

<https://www.gisma.com/blog/what-is-international-marketing-and-why-is-it-important-for-global-business-success>



Executive Summary

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The project examines how businesses succeed internationally by balancing global brand consistency with local adaptation. Standardization can lower costs, while adaptations better meet cultural and consumer needs.

Our findings show that cultural differences shape consumer behavior and advertising reception, meaning that to some extent, it is important to adapt your marketing strategies based on local preferences. However, research also suggests that having a strong and consistent global brand increases trust in consumers and makes your products more recognizable. We found that neither standardization nor adaptation works in isolation; the companies with the most effective marketing maintain a balance between both strategies.



Executive Summary cont'd

Furthermore, businesses wanting to market their products internationally must also choose how they want to enter new markets. Whether it's through direct international exporting, partnerships with foreign businesses, or e-commerce, there are pros and cons that come with each option. Digital marketing has made international marketing a lot more efficient and accessible for companies who know how to navigate and utilize it to their advantage. Digital tools such as social media and online advertising allow companies to reach a wider audience and give them room to test foreign markets without fully committing to them.

Overall, businesses should research each market, analyze competitors, and adjust their marketing strategies to support long-term global growth.



Research Purpose

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A marketing strategy that succeeds in one country may not succeed in another. Differences in language, cultural beliefs, purchasing behavior, and distribution systems affect how people perceive and respond to products and advertising. This leaves companies facing an important strategic question:

How can businesses maintain a consistent international brand while adapting their marketing strategies to the unique conditions of different countries?

Research shows that culture does affect consumer behavior and advertising effectiveness, making local adaptation an important consideration in international marketing.

Background - Culture, Adaptation & Global Branding

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Culture & Consumer Behavior

- Culture affects consumer values, buying behavior, and the response to advertising (De Mooij & Hofstede, 2010).
- U.S. and Thai consumers responded to similar advertising appeals but ranked their importance differently, showing that marketing emphasis should vary by culture (Ruanguttamanun, 2023).

Standardization vs. Adaptation

- Companies should adapt products and marketing when local political, economic, cultural, or consumer conditions differ (Grant et al., 2024).
- Neither standardization nor adaptation is always better; performance depends on how well the strategy fits the specific market (Hultman & Oghazi, 2024).

Global Branding

- Strong global corporate brands can increase consumer trust and purchase intention across countries (Swoboda & Sinning, 2021).
- Keep a recognizable global identity while adapting marketing where local differences matter.

Background - Export Strategy & Digital Global Growth

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Export Marketing Strategy

- Export success is affected by market targeting and the marketing mix, including product and pricing decisions (Leonidou et al., 2002).
- Product advantage is associated with sales, profits, and market share.
- Penetration pricing can support sales growth, while market-based pricing was associated with export intensity and profitability (Leonidou et al., 2002).

Digitalization

- Digital technologies and social media have expanded companies' ability to promote, distribute, and sell internationally (Katsikeas et al., 2020).
- Digital growth also creates challenges including privacy, security, logistics, and increased competition (Katsikeas et al., 2020).

Cross-Border E-Commerce

- Global cross-border e-commerce market value in 2026 was more than double its estimated 2020 value (Ma, 2026).
- Online channels allow companies, including SMEs, to reach foreign consumers with fewer physical barriers.
- Successful international growth requires the right market, marketing mix, and export strategy....supported increasingly by digital channels.

SWOT Analysis

Foundations
(Aidan)

Should we pursue international expansion?

Strengths

- ★ Access to new customers
- ★ More revenue opportunities
- ★ Global brand recognition
- ★ Diversifies sales across markets

Weaknesses

- ★ Higher marketing and operating costs
- ★ Limited international experience
- ★ More complex management
- ★ Difficult for SMEs with fewer resources

Opportunities

- ★ Growing foreign markets
- ★ Cross-border e-commerce
- ★ New customer segments
- ★ Underserved markets

Threats

- ★ Local competitors
- ★ Cultural mistakes
- ★ Tariffs & regulations
- ★ Currency, political & supply-chain risks

Application to Exporting

Applications
(Aidan)

Where should the SME export and how should it enter?

Choosing an Export Market

- Identify countries with demand for the product
- Compare competition, regulations, tariffs & shipping costs
- Select a market that fits the company's resources

Choosing How to Export

- **Direct exporting:** Sell directly to foreign customers or retailers. More control over pricing, branding, and customer relationships, but has manage things like shipping, regulations, and finding customers itself
 - Boeing: Sells aircraft directly to international airline customers
- **Indirect exporting:** Use distributors or other intermediaries. Already understand the market and have established distribution networks
 - Coca-Cola: Uses local bottling and distribution partners worldwide
- **Cross-Border E-commerce:** Sell directly across borders online. Reach foreign customers without immediately establishing physical locations overseas.
 - Amazon: Uses its online marketplace to sell and ship internationally

Overall path for SMEs

- Begin with a limited market and product selection
- Keep initial costs and risks manageable
- Expand after proving demand

Application to the Marketing Mix

Applications
(Aidan)

What parts of our strategy should change?

- Consumer needs, preferences, and purchasing power differ across countries
- Cultural and economic differences mean the same strategy may not work in every market
- Companies should adapt where necessary while keeping their core brand consistent

The 4 Ps (Twin, 2026)

Product: Adapt features, sizes, packaging, or flavors

Price: Consider local income, competition, tariffs, and costs

Place: Choose retailers, distributors, or online channels that fit local buying habits

Promotion: Adjust language, culture, advertising, and messaging

- **Examples of Familiar Brands:**
 - **McDonald's changing menu items**
 - **Coca-Cola adapting advertising**
 - **Netflix adjusting pricing/content.**

Application to Global Branding

Applications
(Aidan)

How do we build recognition and trust across countries?

- **Global Consistency**
 - a. Maintain recognizable brand identity
 - b. Build recognition across countries
- **Consumer Trust**
 - a. Familiar brands can reduce uncertainty
 - b. Corporate reputation can support individual products
- **Local Relevance**
 - a. Adapt messages without changing the core identity
 - b. Connect the global brand with local consumers

GOAL: Recognizable globally + Relevant locally

"Consumers are more likely to buy from a brand they already recognize – even in a new market."

- **Examples of Familiar Brands:**
 - Nestle linking products to its corporate brand
 - Nike adapting campaigns to local markets
 - Apple maintaining a consistent global brand

Application to Digitalization

Applications
(Surmai)

How can digitalization help companies expand their reach?

- Companies are able to reach a **much wider audience** with not too much effort
- **E-commerce platforms** allow companies to **test foreign markets** without having to commit to open physical stores and waste resources
- Digital marketing tools
 - **Social media**
 - **Digital advertising**
 - **Data and analytics**
- Challenges:
 - Harder to make promotions localized to the specific target audience
 - Logistical challenges like shipping, returns, etc
 - Data and privacy laws differing by region

Examples:

- **Shein** - built almost entirely through digital advertising, used worldwide
- **AirBnb** - digital platforms adjusted based on local preferences
- **Amazon** - uses data analytics to tailor online storefront by country

Pros and cons

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Pros for Standardization

- Creates a consistent global brand image
- Reduce advertising and production costs
- Makes international operations easier to manage

Cons for Standardization

- May ignore cultural and language differences
- Products or advertisements may feel irrelevant locally
- Increase the cultural mistakes

Pros for Adaptation

- Responds to local culture and consumer preferences
- Makes products and promotions more relevant
- Strengthens customer trust

Cons for adaptation

- Increase marketing and operating costs
- Requires more research and local expertise
- Makes brand management more complicated

Bottom take away: The strongest international marketing strategy combines global consistency with selective local adaptation

Conclusion and Recommendations

Recommendations:

- 1.) Research each international market before entering it to better understand consumer culture, behavior, competition, and more.
- 2.) Understand and adjust the marketing mix (product, price, place, promotion).
- 3.) Enhance the use of digital tools to reduce barriers of entry.
- 4.) Keep the core brand consistent in order to brand identity and reputation.

Final Thoughts:

- International marketing can create major opportunities for countries to expand their reach, increase revenues, and grow their company.
- There is no universal international marketing approach; it is key to understand that consumers, markets, and regulations vary across borders.
- Successful international marketing = thinking globally + responding locally

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